



Ongoing training
All personnel share skills, including counterterrorist skills in which soldiers learn how to move swiftly in confined spaces *(far right)*. Specialist training depends on the troop a soldier belongs to: Air Troop (airborne insertion), Boat Troop (waterborne insertion), Mobility Troop (land vehicle insertion), or Mountain Troop (climbing and skiing techniques).



"LIKE THE SAS ITSELF, SAS SELECTION IS SIMPLE, DIRECT AND DEADLY EFFECTIVE."

MICHAEL ASHER, SAS TERRITORIAL VOLUNTEER, WRITING IN *SHOOT TO KILL*

If a candidate survives all this, he is officially a member of the regiment. But he will still undergo a great deal more specialist training, which could range from learning foreign languages to rock climbing, free-fall parachuting, or field surgery.

The soldier who emerges from this selection and training process is expected to be well-balanced, self-reliant, and both mentally and physically in peak condition. He must be able to operate in a small unit for long periods under trying conditions without falling out with his colleagues. When necessary he must carry on alone and without orders. The SAS are trained to kill in cold blood when deemed essential, but men considered to have too much of a taste for killing are weeded out. Aggression must be strictly controlled and directed. Keeping a cool head under pressure is a defining characteristic of SAS men. They are neither brawlers nor braggarts. Drill and military "bullshit" (as it is known) are kept to a minimum, with distinction of rank less important than skills and performance.

COUNTER-REVOLUTIONARY WARFARE TACTICS

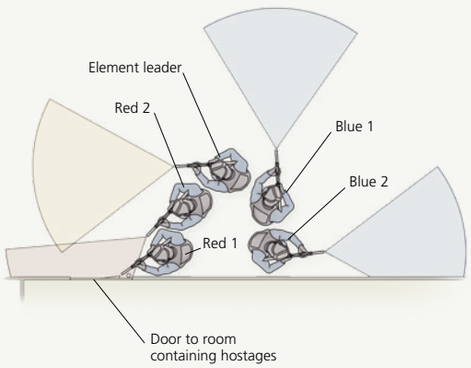
SAS tradition stresses secrecy and anonymity – prating in public about the regiment's activities is totally discouraged. It was the Iranian Embassy siege that transformed the regiment's public profile. In the late 1960s and 1970s, a spate of hostage-taking and airliner hijackings had announced the arrival of international terrorism on the world scene. The SAS responded by setting up a Counter Revolutionary Warfare (CRW) training school at Hereford, where they developed and practised techniques for dealing with hostage situations. There was a "killing house" for exercise in storming buildings where hostages were being held and a mock airliner for practice in dealing with hijackings. CRW instant-readiness teams were formed to respond to a terrorist incident at any time. On 5 May 1980, the years of training were put into effect when an SAS team assaulted the Iranian Embassy building in Prince's Gate, London, where a



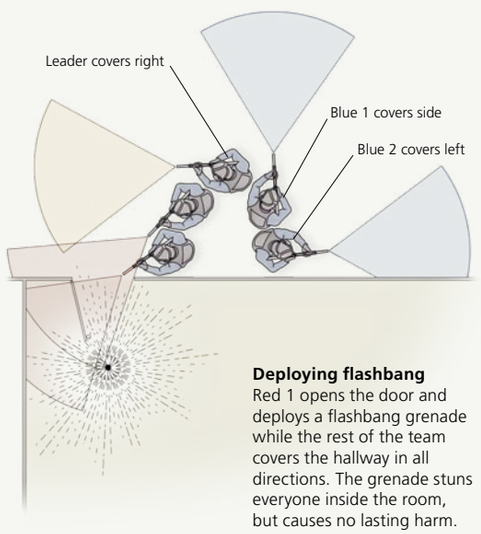
Model of Iranian Embassy
This wooden model of the Iranian Embassy building was made by the SAS to familiarize soldiers with the rooms they would be entering. Each storey was detachable to reveal the layout of the floor beneath.

ENTRY TACTICS

In the 1970s, the SAS played a prominent role in the development of tactics for entering buildings occupied by hostile armed groups holding hostages. The first problem was to gain entry, which might involve blowing in windows or doors with controlled charges. The next step was to disorientate the hostage-takers by throwing in stun grenades or CS gas grenades. Small armed units would follow a thoroughly rehearsed procedure to sweep the whole space rapidly with their automatic weapons, identifying any hostile presence. They were strictly trained to avoid risks of shooting one another or innocent hostages. Each man would be positioned so that no other member of the team came within his line of fire at any time. It was SAS policy to shoot all hostage-takers dead, thus preventing the activation of concealed explosive devices.



Stacking up
A typical entry team consists of five men; Red 1 and Red 2, who head the team, the element leader, who holds the middle, and Blue 1 and Blue 2 at the rear. To clear a room, the teams starts by "stacking up" at the side of the door where the handle is located.



Deploying flashbang
Red 1 opens the door and deploys a flashbang grenade while the rest of the team covers the hallway in all directions. The grenade stuns everyone inside the room, but causes no lasting harm.